

## ARTICLE

# When politicians behave badly: Political, democratic, and social consequences of political incivility

Troels Bøggild<sup>1</sup> | Carsten Jensen<sup>2</sup>

<sup>1</sup>Associate Professor, Department of Political Science, Aarhus University, Aarhus C, Denmark

<sup>2</sup>Professor, Department of Political Science, Aarhus University, Aarhus C, Denmark

**Correspondence**

Troels Bøggild, Associate Professor, Department of Political Science, Aarhus University, Bartholins Allé 7, 8000 Aarhus C, Denmark.  
Email: [tboeggild@ps.au.dk](mailto:tboeggild@ps.au.dk)

**Abstract**

Many citizens find politics too uncivil, and incivility is often considered a source of political disaffection. However, research studying these effects almost exclusively relies on survey experiments, which yield contrasting results depending on design choices and do not study downstream consequences for satisfaction with democracy and compliance with public policy. We present a theoretical argument on these downstream consequences and study how citizens respond to political incivility in their real-life information environment using a multi-wave survey panel of 6055 Danish citizens with 18,805 interviews spanning 18 months. Using generalized difference-in-differences models and a natural experiment, we demonstrate nontrivial adverse effects of political incivility on political trust, satisfaction with democracy, and intentions to comply with policies, while intentions to vote are unaffected. Our results highlight how elite rhetoric shapes support for the political system and policy compliance and pinpoint the potential and pitfalls of survey experiments and our own panel approach.

Many citizens believe that politics has an “incivility problem” (Bentivegna & Rega, 2022; Sydnor, 2019). In the United States, for example, 69% consider the government uncivil, and two thirds believe that the problem is worsening (GU Politics, 2022; Pew Research Center, 2019). These perceptions are, at least in part, rooted in reality: Uncivil exchanges between politicians, such as personal insults, interruptions, and nonverbal gestures, are increasingly common (Frimer et al., 2023; Geer, 2006) and broadcasted widely through the media, social media algorithms, and online sharing by elites and ordinary citizens (Frimer et al., 2023; Milli et al., 2023; Skytte, 2019).

Scholars, pundits, and politicians themselves have expressed concerns that this development may affect the fundamental health of democracies (Strachan & Wolf, 2012; Weber Shandwick, 2019). Incivility may not

only affect public trust in the politicians who exhibit such incivility but also carry important downstream consequences for citizens’ satisfaction with democracy at large and compliance with its policies. In Norris’ (2017) terms, incivility may decrease specific support for political actors as well as more general, diffuse support for the political system and its capacity for problem solving (see also Easton, 1957).

Although the stakes may, indeed, be high, the scientific literature does not provide clear insights into the consequences of increasing political incivility. Previous research has theorized a link between politicians’ incivility and public trust in politicians, but empirical results remain mixed (for a meta-analysis, see Van’t Riet & Van Stekelenburg, 2022). This likely reflects that most studies rely on survey experiments whose results vary according to design features and statistical power

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The Cornell Center for Social Sciences verified that the data and replication code submitted to the AJPS Dataverse replicates the numerical results reported in the main text of this article.

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(Skytte, 2022; Van't Riet & Van Stekelenburg, 2022). In contrast, no work provides a theoretical framework or empirical analysis of the potential downstream consequences for satisfaction with democracy or policy compliance. Examining such effects would likely be a tall order in a single-shot survey experiment; yet, they are important. If political incivility affects the health of democratic systems, we need to understand how far the infection travels and which functions it may impede.

This article accommodates these shortcomings on three levels. At the theoretical level, we present an argument that political incivility adversely affects not just citizens' trust in politicians but also broader satisfaction with the democratic system and policy compliance. We arrive at these expectations by integrating insights from social and political psychology into the literature on political incivility.

At the methodological level, we test this framework with a three-stage setup that accommodates the shortcomings of the traditional survey experiment while maintaining strong causal identification. In stage 1, we develop and validate a scale tapping citizens' perceptions of political incivility and show that these measured perceptions reliably track real-world changes in elite rhetoric. In stage 2, we embed this scale in a multi-wave panel survey with 6055 Danish respondents and a total of 18,805 interviews from May 2019 to October 2020. We use generalized difference-in-differences models to estimate how citizens respond when they experience changes in political incivility, controlling for perceptions of politicians' conflict on substantial issues. In stage 3, we apply a different identification strategy by exploiting a sudden, exogenous shock that reduced political incivility rather than relying on measured perceptions of incivility. Specifically, we exploit a natural experiment as the COVID-19 crisis broke out during our data collection process. In several countries, including Denmark, the COVID-19 crisis elicited a "rally 'round the flag effect," resulting in sudden increases in political trust and satisfaction with democracy (Vries et al., 2021). The primary theoretical explanation for this effect is that such crises induce a halt in opposition attacks against the government (Brody & Shapiro, 1989; Hetherington & Nelson, 2003). Our data provide a unique opportunity for testing whether this rally effect can, at least in part, be attributed to a sudden drop in incivility—but not conflict on substantial issues—between politicians.

At the empirical level, we report three consistent findings across identification strategies. First, we find a negative effect of political incivility on trust in politicians. Moreover, and in line with previous work, we find no effect on citizens' intentions to vote in national elections. Second, we find consistent support for our theory of downstream consequences. Political incivility depresses citizens' satisfaction with democracy

and compliance with COVID-19 restrictions. Third, we consistently find that politicians' incivility—and not conflict on substantial issues—drives these negative effects.

Our study offers both methodological and substantive lessons. Methodologically, the study offers an integrated approach to studying effects of elite rhetoric on broader systemic attitudes and policy compliance that may be difficult to grasp in the traditional survey experiment. We discuss how some—though not all—criticisms against the survey experimental approach are worth accommodating through complementary research designs. Finally, we highlight the strengths and shortcomings of our panel data approach and which conclusions it, in conjunction with the existing survey experimental literature, allows us to draw.

Substantively, we believe that our findings point to discernible, negative political and social consequences of uncivil behavior between politicians. The results furthermore underline that citizens are not repelled by conflict between politicians on political issues and are able to distinguish issue-related conflict from uncivil personal interactions (see also Brooks & Geer, 2007; Skytte, 2021). This implies that it is—at least theoretically—possible to achieve high public trust in politicians, satisfaction with democracy, and policy compliance in a democracy with fierce political competition between elites as long as competition remains issue-based and politicians stick to norms of civil behavior.

## POLITICAL INCIVILITY: CONCEPT AND CONSEQUENCES

While there is no commonly shared definition of political incivility, recent research has largely converged around the notion that it reflects a lack of politeness and respect in the interactions between politicians (Brooks & Geer, 2007; Funk, 2001; Mutz, 2015). This may entail a lack of respect for an opponent's arguments or their general character and is reflected in both verbal communications such as interrupting, ignoring, or insulting opponents and nonverbal gestures such as eye-rolling and sighing (Muddiman, 2017; Stryker et al., 2016). Hence, incivility does not refer to substantive disagreement or conflict between politicians on political issues but a lack of adherence to norms of social interaction.

Several studies suggest that uncivil exchanges in politics have been on the rise in Western democracies, and as a result, political incivility is often considered a main driver of current political disaffection among Western publics (Dodd & Schraufnagel, 2013; Frimer et al., 2023; Shea & Sproveri, 2012; Sobieraj & Berry, 2011; West, 2013). Although uncivil messages still constitute a relatively small proportion of

all communication from politicians, they are overrepresented in the information flow available to citizens due to extensive coverage and engagement from traditional media and social media algorithms and users (Bøggild et al., 2021; Frimer et al., 2023; Milli et al., 2023; Skytte, 2019). Yet, the empirical evidence on the link between incivility and political disaffection remains unclear on two counts. First, the bulk of studies focuses on effects on trust in politicians or participation in elections without attention to broader, downstream consequences for evaluations of the political system or compliance with its policies. Trust in politicians is certainly an important concept, but it is often studied because it is believed to have downstream consequences for citizens' broader support for the system and policy compliance (Easton, 1957). Second, the studies focusing on political trust and election participation report mixed evidence. Some studies find negative effects of political incivility on trust in politicians and engagement in politics (Brooks & Geer, 2007; Forgette & Morris, 2006; Mutz & Reeves, 2005; Skytte, 2021) while others find no effects on political trust or none or even positive effects on political engagement and participation (Brooks & Geer, 2007; Mutz, 2015; Paris, 2017; Sydnor, 2019).<sup>1</sup> A recent meta-analysis of experimental research on political incivility (Van't Riet & Van Stekelenburg, 2022) found no average effect on political participation and a small average negative effect on political trust but with some indications of publication bias against null findings.

We believe that this lack of clarity reflects shortcomings at the theoretical and methodological levels. At the theoretical level, we lack a framework for understanding the potential downstream consequences of political incivility. The literature contains well-founded and intuitive arguments on the relationships between incivility and trust in politicians as well as election participation. Uncivil behavior by politicians breaks with basic norms of social interactions, which should make citizens less inclined to trust such individuals (Forgette & Morris, 2006; Mutz & Reeves, 2005). For election participation, there are likely countervailing mechanisms at work since incivility can both lead citizens to disengage from an increasingly hostile and uncomfortable political environment (Sydnor, 2019) and serve as entertainment that draws people in (Brooks & Geer, 2007; Mutz & Reeves, 2005). What is missing is a theoretical link between uncivil behavior between politicians and broader systemic attitudes and compliance among citizens.

At the methodological level, almost the entire literature relies on a single research design, that is, the survey experiment. Survey experiments are particularly valuable due to their potential to ensure internal valid-

ity but often put citizens in stylized settings that do not fully emulate how they form opinions in their real-life information environment. Given what we know from decades of research on political opinion formation, this can lead to both over- and underestimating the effects of political incivility in at least three ways.

First, large parts of the citizenry pay little attention to, or deliberately avoid, political debates (Carpini et al., 1996; Slothuus, 2016) and may, therefore, not notice real-world (changes in) incivility between politicians. This tendency among citizens is typically not emulated in experimental studies on political incivility, which treat all research participants with political information regardless of their inclination to receive such information in a real-life information environment and often exclude subjects that fail attention checks (but see Gaines & Kuklinski, 2011, and Leeper, 2017, on design features that allow for controlling for and testing self-selection in experimental research). This may bias the estimated effects of political incivility upwards.

Second, to the extent that citizens do receive information that allows them to form perceptions of political incivility in the real world, such information is often less extreme than the typical information provided in experimental studies. Many experimental studies tend to include extreme depictions of incivility between politicians that are not representative of political debates to maximize variation on the independent variable (Skytte, 2022). This design choice may lead to overestimating the effects of political incivility.

Third, citizens form opinions continuously as they obtain new information (Chong & Druckman, 2010) and may, as a result, not change their opinions substantially based on a single uncivil exchange between politicians. Yet, experiments on political incivility are most often one-shot designs in which participants are assigned to varying degrees of uncivil exchanges between a few politicians and subsequently asked questions about political trust and participation. Hence, the one-shot design may underestimate how general, aggregate changes in political incivility over time change citizens' attitudes (Van't Riet & Van Stekelenburg, 2022, pp. 219–220). This one-shot experimental setup is likely also a reason why the literature has mainly studied effects on citizens' trust in politicians and not on broader outcomes such as satisfaction with democracy or intentions to comply with public policy. Demonstrating such effects based on experimental vignettes portraying uncivil exchanges between concrete politicians would likely be a tall order. We believe advancing the literature on the consequences of political incivility requires a methodological approach that accommodates these shortcomings and considers existing knowledge on how citizens form opinions in their natural environment.

<sup>1</sup> Evidence is also mixed in the literature on negative campaigning (or campaign tone), which may capture differences in incivility but also taps variation in politicians' focus on political failures versus successes, political scandals, and so forth (Brooks & Geer, 2007).

Below, we lay out an argument that provides the missing theoretical link and subsequently present a combination of research designs that study citizens' reactions to political incivility in their real-life information environment while approximating the internal validity of the randomized experiment.

## Downstream consequences of political incivility

Despite limited attention to the broader implications of incivility, it is well established that other aspects of politicians' behavior can have downstream consequences for systemic attitudes and policy compliance among citizens. As predicted by Easton (1957) more than half a century ago, systematic change in incumbent politicians' behavior can affect general satisfaction with and support for the political system and compliance with its policies. Two lines of empirical research support this prediction. First, satisfaction with democracy and policy compliance is a function of whether politicians produce policies that are in line with the ideological and material interests of citizens and the outcomes they deliver such as the development of the national economy (Miller & Listhaug, 1999). Second, over and above results, citizens base systemic attitudes and compliance on politicians' adherence to democratic principles such as impartiality, openness, and transparency in policymaking (Hibbing & Theiss-Morse, 2001). While well established that such inherently *political* behavior has downstream consequences, it remains an open question whether *social*, interpersonal behavior of politicians has similar effects.

Building on research in social and political psychology, we argue that it does. One key insight from social psychology is that people have a natural tendency to ascribe human properties to abstract social systems and organizations. Just like we tend to see human faces in natural objects such as clouds and trees, we assign human traits such as "evil" or "caring" to, for instance, corporations and agencies (often denoted organizational anthropomorphism, see Ashforth et al., 2020). Importantly, such trait impressions are, in part, formed by observing the behavior of agents who represent the system, particularly leaders (Ashforth et al., 2020). On this basis, research on interpersonal justice demonstrates that managers' informal interactions shape general perceptions of the workplace with important downstream implications (for a review, see Bies, 2015). Leaders who violate norms of social interaction such as shouting or showing disrespect toward others—key constituents of incivility—alienate subordinates not only by reducing trust in management but also by decreasing broader support for and identification with the company and behavioral

compliance with organizational guidelines and orders (Charoensap et al., 2019; Cohen-Charash & Spector, 2001; Wenzel, 2006).

Two motivations underlie people's tendency to base systemic attitudes and compliance on the social behavior of leaders, and we expect that both should apply in the domain of politics as well. One motivation is sensemaking. Evaluating a system or organization according to its objective properties, such as its formal rules or organizational structure, is cognitively demanding. Substituting toward human trait-based inferences frees up cognitive resources and allows for easier inferences because the mind forms such evaluations on a regular basis in small-scale social interactions and possesses efficient psychological mechanisms for their computation (Petersen, 2012; Tooby & Cosmides, 1992). This task should be no less cognitively demanding when evaluating democratic systems with their inherently complex and remote decision-making procedures. Indeed, citizens exhibit limited understanding of democratic institutions such as electoral systems and checks and balances (Carpini et al., 1996; Klosko, 2004) but are capable of forming fast and frugal trait-based inferences of politicians with above-chance accuracy (Bøggild, 2020a; Lin et al., 2018).

Another motivation for turning to leaders' social behavior is that it helps the individual evaluate its relationship with the system. Individuals process this relationship as a simple social exchange relationship based on reciprocity (Ashforth et al., 2020; Bøggild, 2020a; Rousseau, 1989): In exchange for their support to the system and decision compliance, the individual expects that the system considers and attends to citizens' welfare. Such information is readily available when we evaluate dyadic relationships with other individuals through verbal and nonverbal signs of, for example, empathy and assertiveness; however, valid information is sparse when we evaluate systems such as companies or political systems. Instead, individuals turn to leaders' social behavior to infer whether the system embodies traits that indicate attentiveness to citizens' welfare (Ashforth et al., 2020). We expect that citizens turn to incivility between politicians for such evaluations as incivility signals assertiveness, intolerance, and lack of warmth and communal interest (Leary & Kowalski, 1990; Mölders et al., 2017; Walter, 2021). In short, citizens should use information on the degree of incivility as a diagnostic tool to assess whether politicians and the political system "care" or are indifferent about their welfare and well-being<sup>2</sup> and adjust their trust in politicians, satisfaction

<sup>2</sup> Below, we present, at least tentative, evidence for this causal mechanism, suggesting that changes in incivility make citizens ascribe such traits to politicians.



with the democratic system, and policy compliance accordingly.

## CASE SELECTION AND DATA SOURCES

We rely on panel survey data, tracking a sample of 6055 Danish citizens for 1.5 years (from May 2019 to October 2020).<sup>3</sup> As explained in detail below, this setup allows us to observe how citizens respond when experiencing a change in political incivility over time compared to others experiencing no change in the same period (i.e., variants of the difference-in-differences design).

Denmark is typical of most Western representative democracies on at least two major counts. First, Denmark is a multiparty system. The two biggest parties are the Social Democrats (a mainstream left-of-center party), which won 25.9% of the vote in the 2019 election, and the Liberal Party (a mainstream right-of-center party), which won 23.4%. Equally fragmented party systems are found across Europe.

Second, electoral competition is fierce, and government power has shifted frequently. In 2011, a coalition government led by the Liberal Party lost power to a coalition led by the Social Democrats, which again lost to the Liberal Party in 2015, only to see power flip back to the Social Democrats in 2019. No comparative data exist on the extent of uncivil political rhetoric in Denmark vis-à-vis other countries, but research suggests that the intense fight for power comes with widespread negativity in Danish election campaigns (Elmelund-Præstekær & Mølgaard-Svensson, 2014). That said, we presume that Denmark is characterized by less incivility than, for example, the United States, which is arguably an extreme case with its rampant social and political polarization (Boxell et al., 2020; but see Wagner, 2021).

Denmark also stands out, especially when it comes to three of our outcome variables: Danes generally express higher trust in politicians and satisfaction with democracy and are more inclined to vote (Bøggild, 2020b). There is no indication that this reflects that Danish citizens inherently form opinions about politicians and the political system differently from other nationalities; rather, such country differences seem to reflect differences in inequality, corruption levels, and social capital (Norris, 2011). For these reasons, we do not expect that Danish citizens would respond differently to political incivility. A potential upside is that we may avoid underestimating the effects of incivility due

to risks of floor effects if large numbers of participants had initial chronic dissatisfaction with politicians and politics.

Through the survey company YouGov, we fielded a well-powered panel survey ( $n = 6055$ ) with respondents matching the Danish population on age, gender, education, and geographical location. In the first wave of the study, participants were randomly divided into three subsamples ( $n$  between 1983 and 2061) that were all launched 8 to 9 days apart in May 2019. Subsequently, we reinterviewed the respondents of each subsample twice but at different points in time, amounting to three waves of survey responses covering nine different time points. This rolling reinterview design (Leeper & Slothuus, 2016) allows us to closely follow participants for 18 months as changes to their real-life information environment occur.

The third round of interviews in the first subsample was conducted in February 2020—just weeks before the COVID-19 crisis broke out in Denmark. We took advantage of this sudden, drastic change in participants' information environment by collecting three additional rounds of reinterviews of this subsample in March, April, and May 2020. As explained below, this additional data allow us to analyze the effects of a real-world sudden shock that changed the level of incivility between politicians. Moreover, the data offer a unique setting for studying the effects of political incivility on compliance with a concrete new set of policies and guidelines of crucial importance for society.

In sum, subsamples 2 and 3 were interviewed three times, whereas subsample 1 was interviewed six times. This amounts to 18,805 survey responses covering 12 different time points within 18 months. Details on field periods and attrition rates for each subsample are available on page 2 in Section A of the Supplementary Information (SI). Below, we explain how these data allow us to adopt two different research designs that exploit different types of variation in political incivility.

## RESEARCH DESIGNS AND MEASURES

The panel data allow us to adopt two variants of the difference-in-differences design. Each design has strengths and shortcomings, but in combination, they offer a strong test of the consequences of political incivility with attention to both internal and external validity.

### The generalized difference-in-differences design

First, we employ what is often referred to as the generalized difference-in-differences design. Here, we estimate the effects based on differences in subjective

<sup>3</sup> Our study raises no ethical concerns with experimental interventions, deception, or unequal treatment of subjects. It complies with national regulations and professional guidelines for studying human subjects and follows data protection regulations. According to Danish regulations, our study was exempt from formal IRB review (see Section G of the SI). Participants provided informed consent.

perceptions of political incivility between and within subjects across all collected survey waves. Specifically, we use two-way fixed-effects estimation to rule out a series of potential confounders. By observing the effects of incivility *within* individuals over time, we rule out confounding from time-invariant factors (e.g., stable dispositions such as personality traits) that may correlate with both perceived political incivility and the outcome variables of interest. By simultaneously estimating the effects *between* individuals within each survey wave, we reduce risks of confounding from society-wide, time-variant factors. For example, a national election and change in government occurred between the first and second survey waves, which could affect perceptions of incivility as well as political trust. Adding time dummies allows us to account for such macro-level developments. In addition, we control for participants' political interest, ideology, perceptions of the economy, and perceived issue-based political conflict, which could correlate with both within- and between-subject perceptions of political incivility and some of our outcome variables. Especially perceptions of political conflict may covary with perceptions of political incivility and confound its relationship with, for example, political trust and participation (Brooks & Geer, 2007; Skytte, 2021).

In this design, the parallel trends assumption is key, implying that respondents would have followed parallel developments or trajectories in our outcome variables if they had not experienced different levels of political incivility (Angrist & Pischke, 2008; Goodman-Bacon, 2021). While this assumption cannot be directly proven, we can support it by testing if respondents who experience a change in political incivility from  $t_0$  to  $t_1$  exhibit the same pre-trend—and preferably also the same pre-level—in the outcome variables as those who do not experience a change in the same period (Angrist & Pischke, 2008).

To bolster the parallel trends assumption, we conduct three types of robustness tests. First, we include unit-specific linear time trends, which capture smooth changes in unobserved confounders. In practice, this corresponds to adding another set of fixed effects for the interaction between the individual and time variables, which ensures that potentially time-varying confounding is controlled out (see, e.g., Dinas et al., 2019; Jørgensen et al., 2022). While some controversy remains over whether to include unit trends, the concern is that it may constitute a conservative test by biasing coefficients toward zero (Goodman-Bacon, 2021).

Second, we add a lead on the estimated effect of political incivility (i.e., political incivility at  $t_1$ ). This allows for a test of whether a change in the outcome variable at  $t-1$  to  $t_0$  correlates with a change in perceptions of political incivility from  $t_0$  to  $t_1$ . Absent such a

correlation, we can be confident that experiencing a change in political incivility over time is not a function of prior levels of, for example, political trust, satisfaction with democracy, or vote intentions (see Dinas et al., 2019; Jørgensen et al., 2022). In our design, it is crucial to rule out that general sentiments about politics (e.g., trust in politicians and satisfaction with democracy) affect subjects' responses to the incivility measures.

Third, to rule out potential bias from selective attrition, we report all analyses with both an unbalanced panel (minimizing attrition and maximizing sample representativeness) and a balanced panel (maximizing internal validity). In addition, we weight observations in waves 2–6 to match the representative subsamples in wave 1 on age, gender, education, and geographical location.

Importantly, none of these robustness tests systematically changes the findings in terms of statistical significance. Even when all robustness tests are applied simultaneously, the coefficients remain statistically significant and are close to the estimates of the unconstrained two-way fixed-effects models.

### The specific or event-based difference-in-differences design

The second research design differs by exploiting a specific event-based shock to the level of political incivility in respondents' information environment that occurred in between closely collected survey waves. The design adds important nuance to the approach in the first design in two ways. First, it offers a different causal identification strategy by examining the downstream effects of a politically exogenous event that caused a sudden change in the level of incivility between politicians. Second, it adds further realism by studying the effects of incivility in relation to a high-profile real-world event where existing theory suggests that the level of incivility should change and, in turn, affect our outcome variables.

Specifically, we exploit a natural experiment as the COVID-19 crisis broke out during our data collection process. National security crises often lead to a rally-'round-the-flag' effect by increasing trust in government and politicians and satisfaction with democracy. The dominant theoretical explanation for this effect is that such crises induce a halt in opposition attacks against the government (Brody & Shapiro, 1989; Hetherington & Nelson, 2003). The rally effect itself is well established, also in relation to the COVID-19 crisis and the Danish case (Vries et al., 2021). It is also well established that oppositions generally do hold back on attacking governing parties when national security crises break out

(Chowanietz, 2011).<sup>4</sup> What is less well established is whether the rally effect can reasonably be attributed to such changes in political discourse. We do not know, for example, if citizens even notice such changes in their information environment or if the rally effect emerges because citizens experience less incivility or less issue-based conflict in politics (page 3 in Section B of the SI elaborates on theories and empirical evidence backing the link between national security crises and opposition rhetoric).

These questions linger because national security crises are often sudden and unanticipated events, and as such, they are inherently difficult for researchers to predict and prepare for. Indeed, crises are supposed to be unpredictable and exogenous if we are to estimate their true effect, meaning that the most suitable empirical cases are also the most difficult to study (Gerber & Green, 2012). As a result, studies often rely on secondary data that do not allow for teasing apart competing theoretical mechanisms.

More out of luck than foresight, one of our subsamples was collected only weeks before the COVID-19 crisis broke out in Denmark. The subsample contained numerous measures for not only observing how political trust, satisfaction with democracy, and so forth changed as a result of the crisis but also how such changes relate to changes in perceived political incivility and issue-based political conflict among respondents.

Specifically, the data allow us to test two observable implications. First, changes in respondents' trust in politicians and satisfaction with democracy elicited by the COVID-19 crisis should track changes in perceived political incivility—and not issue-based conflict (pages 3–10 in Section B of the SI discuss and report robustness analyses that rule out alternative interpretations such as changes in policy content, bipartisan cooperation, or systematic attrition).

Second, the crisis should elicit larger rally effects among government supporters relative to opposition supporters (i.e., a difference-in-differences logic).<sup>5</sup> Previous work demonstrates that citizens across partisan divides respond with outrage and disaffection to uncivil comments but that the effects are stronger when incivility targets the party they support (Frimer & Skitka, 2018; Mutz, 2015; Skytte, 2022). For our case, the expectation follows the same logic but is slightly different: Given that the opposition in this instance should become *less* likely to communicate uncivil messages about the government, we expect the associated positive effects on political trust and satisfaction

with democracy to be particularly pronounced among supporters of the governing parties who are suddenly being “de-targeted” for uncivil attacks. This pattern should emerge if a sudden drop in political incivility does, in fact, help elicit the rally effect.

Note that this design differs from a typical event-based difference-in-differences design in which one group is treated and the other is not. In our case, both left-wing and right-wing party supporters should receive the treatment, but the difference in party identification should enhance the impact of the treatment for the former group compared to the latter (e.g., Lenz, 2012; Slothuus & Bisgaard, 2021). Since left-wing supporters, in principle, could respond with higher levels of political trust and satisfaction with democracy for other reasons than the change in incivility, we report a set of robustness analyses on pages 8–10 in Section B of the SI. Again, the appropriateness of this design hinges on the parallel trends assumption. Since this design uses a specific event-based shock, we test and graphically illustrate pre-trends and pre-levels between left-wing and right-wing party supporters in the analysis section below.

In all analyses below, we report results from ordinary least squares (OLS) regression with participant-level clustered standard errors.

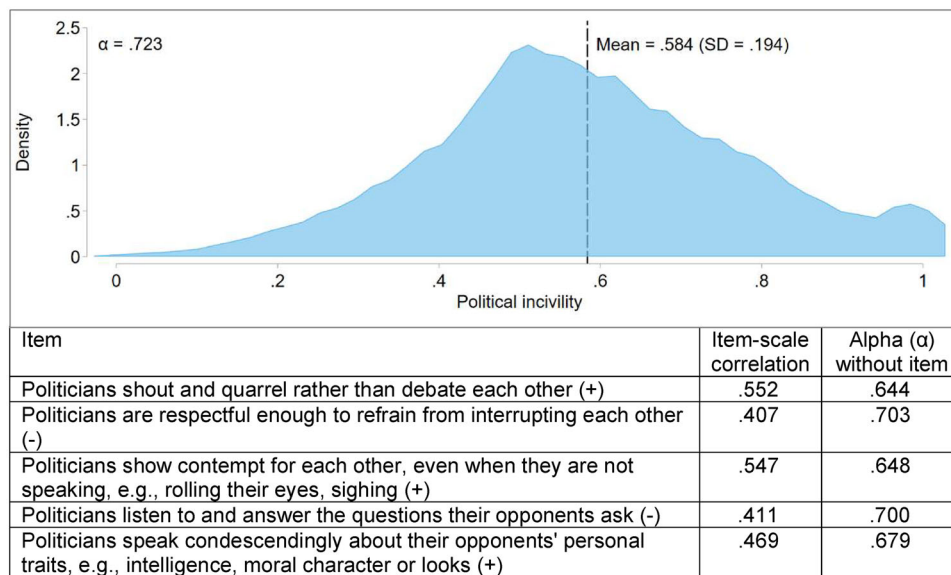
## Measures

We measure our independent variable—perceptions of political incivility—through a five-item index. The items (reported in Figure 1) include five statements that were answered on a scale of 1–7 where 1 is “Completely disagree” and 7 “Completely agree,” including a “Don’t know” option. In line with the definition above, the statements tapped perceptions of both verbal and nonverbal forms of incivility and behavior targeting opponents’ arguments as well as general character traits. The statements were phrased in both positive and negative direction to avoid response set bias (Villar, 2008). To avoid potential social desirability bias, respondents read a short introductory text noting that some find the tone in political debates “overly coarse and uncivil” while others find that politicians “display courtesy and respect towards each other” (see page 11 in Section C of the SI for the full wording; Daoust et al., 2021). The items were summarized into an additive index that was rescaled 0–1, indicating minimum and maximum levels of political incivility, respectively. The distribution of the index is displayed in the upper part of Figure 1, showing that most Danish citizens experience a moderate level of political incivility, with some respondents reporting very high perceptions of political incivility ( $M = .584$ ;  $SD = .194$ ).

To validate our scale, we performed three types of tests. First, we conducted reliability tests to ensure

<sup>4</sup> Danes even have a word for this phenomenon, *borgfred*, meaning peace (*fred*) in the parliamentary building (*Christiansborg*).

<sup>5</sup> We define government supporters as anyone voting for the governing party (the Social Democrats) or its parliamentary support parties (the Unity List, Socialist People's Party, Social Liberals, and the Greens). Opposition supporters refer to supporters of other parties.



**FIGURE 1** Items, reliability, and descriptives of political incivility index. *Note:* Descriptive statistics, distribution (kernel density), and survey items of political incivility index. Only data from wave 1 included to avoid bias from attrition.  $N = 5651$ .

that all items tap the same underlying concept. As reported in Figure 1, all items display acceptable item-scale correlations ( $r = .407-.552$ ) and contribute to the overall reliability of the index ( $\alpha = .723$ ) in the Danish sample. Before conducting the panel survey, we included the items in an American convenience sample recruited through Amazon Mechanical Turk ( $N = 515$ ), which displayed similar reliability and descriptive statistics ( $\alpha = .800$ ;  $M = .656$ ;  $SD = .211$ ; see page 11 in Section C of the SI).<sup>6</sup> Second, we tested the measurement validity of the index to ensure that the perceptions measured over time systematically track real-world changes in the tone and incivility between politicians. Following the logic of our specific difference-in-differences design above, we analyzed 1470 news articles from January to June 2020 using both manual, human coding of the general tone toward the government and a semi-supervised machine learning approach, measuring uncivil language toward the government (for procedures and validity tests, see pages 14–17 in Section E of the SI). As demonstrated below, we find that the COVID-19 crisis did, in fact, lead to a more positive tone and less uncivil language toward the government. Importantly, this sudden change is also evident in our survey data, showing that perceived political incivility dropped immediately following the COVID-19 crisis. Third, we further tested the measurement validity of the index by merging the media data and survey data. Using individual-level fixed effects, we show that the

participants systematically adjust their perceptions of political incivility over time according to real-world changes in the tone and incivility between politicians in the media (see pages 16–17 in Section E of the SI).

The panel surveys also included measures of our four dependent variables. First, we measured trust in politicians through a single item used and validated in the Danish National Election Study: “How much trust do you generally have in politicians in Parliament [*Folketinget*]?” on a 1 (no trust) to 7 (high level of trust) scale that was rescaled 0–1 ( $M = .475$ ;  $SD = .246$ ). Second, satisfaction with democracy was measured using another standard item asking: “How satisfied or dissatisfied are you with the way that democracy works in Denmark?” with the response categories “Very unsatisfied,” “Slightly unsatisfied,” “Somewhat satisfied,” and “Very satisfied” ( $M = .657$ ;  $SD = .283$ ). Note that we do not measure effects on citizens’ support for abstract democratic values or principles but evaluations of how the democratic regime works in practice (Norris, 2017). Third, we measured vote intentions by asking which party respondents would vote for and recoded this variable 1 for participants responding “would not vote” and 0 for all other respondents. Fourth, in waves 5 and 6 collected after the COVID-19 crisis broke out, we measured willingness to comply with COVID-19 restrictions through an additive index of four items answered on a 0 (not at all willing) to 10 (fully willing) scale: “Refrain from meeting with family and close friends,” “Refrain from inviting guests into your home,” “Avoid gathering more than 10 people,” and “Avoid staying in public places like parks and playgrounds with lots of people.” The index was

<sup>6</sup> Incivility was 7.2 percentage points higher in the US sample. This is in line with our reasoning regarding case selection above, although differences in sampling, representativeness, and timing make a direct comparison difficult.



**TABLE 1** Effect of incivility on trust in politicians.

|                          | (1)               | (2)               | (3)               | (4)               | (5)               | (6)               |
|--------------------------|-------------------|-------------------|-------------------|-------------------|-------------------|-------------------|
| Incivility               | -.177**<br>(.013) | -.165**<br>(.019) | -.142**<br>(.021) | -.147**<br>(.024) | -.134**<br>(.032) | -.133**<br>(.031) |
| Incivility <sup>†1</sup> | –                 | –                 | –                 | –                 | .012<br>(.032)    | .017<br>(.031)    |
| Respondent fixed effects | ✓                 | ✓                 | ✓                 | ✓                 | ✓                 | ✓                 |
| Wave fixed effects       | ✓                 | ✓                 | ✓                 | ✓                 | ✓                 | ✓                 |
| Unit trends              | –                 | –                 | ✓                 | ✓                 | ✓                 | ✓                 |
| Balanced panel           | –                 | ✓                 | –                 | ✓                 | –                 | ✓                 |
| Observations             | 13,677            | 5085              | 13,677            | 5085              | 8206              | 4159              |
| Respondents              | 4149              | 963               | 4149              | 963               | 2842              | 937               |

*Note:* Entries are coefficients from ordinary least squares (OLS) regressions testing effects of incivility on trust in politicians with respondent-level clustered standard errors in parentheses.

\* $p < .05$ , \*\* $p < .01$ .

rescaled 0–1 and showed acceptable reliability and variation ( $\alpha = .834$ ;  $M = .775$ ;  $SD = .225$ ).

The survey also included five control variables. First, we asked about participants' interest in politics on a 1 (no interest) to 4 (high interest) scale, which was rescaled 0–1 ( $M = .635$ ;  $SD = .268$ ). Second, we measured subjects' perceptions of political conflict on the four most salient issues in Danish politics during the data collection process, namely, immigration, the environment, old age pensions, and health care (Bøggild & Jensen, 2023). On a 1 (no disagreement) to 7 (large disagreement) scale, which was rescaled 0–1, we asked: "On some issues, there is greater political disagreement between the parties in Parliament than on other issues. Please state how much political disagreement there is for each of these four issues." Conflict perceptions on these four issues were weakly to moderately correlated with our index of political incivility ( $r = .080$ – $.195$ ). This is important for two reasons. First, it highlights that our measure of political incivility exhibits discriminant validity and does not simply capture perceptions of substantive conflict on high-salience issues. Subjects are able to discriminate between these concepts. Second, it highlights that controlling for perceptions of substantial political conflict is important to obtain a clean estimate of the effects of political incivility.

## EVIDENCE FROM 18 MONTHS OF PANEL DATA

Does experiencing an increase in political incivility reduce citizens' trust in politicians, satisfaction with democracy, and intentions to vote? Tables 1 and 2 provide the first set of answers based on the generalized difference-in-differences design.

Table 1 shows the effect of political incivility on trust in politicians while including respondent and wave fixed effects and controlling for political interest, ideology, perceptions of the economy, and perceptions of political conflict. Model 1 uses the full panel data (i.e., all subjects interviewed at least twice) and reports a substantial and significant 17.7 percentage point drop in political trust as political incivility changes from its minimum (0) to its maximum (1) value. Model 2 restricts the analysis to subjects in subsample 1 who were interviewed in all six waves and shows a similar 16.5 percentage point negative effect on political trust. Models 3 and 4 show that these results remain substantial and significant after adding unit-specific linear time trends, amounting to 14.2 and 14.7 percentage points, respectively. Models 5 and 6 furthermore add a lead of the political incivility variable to test if respondents follow similar pre-trends in the outcome variable regardless of whether they experience a change in political incivility or not. Reassuringly, the lead effect is very close to zero and statistically insignificant while the main estimate remains significant in both Models 5 and 6, amounting to 13.4 and 13.3 percentage points, respectively.

In other words, subjects reporting changes in political incivility are similar to and follow the same prior trajectory in political trust as those who report no change in political incivility. Even in the most constrained models, the negative effect of political incivility differs by a maximum of 4.4 percentage points compared to the unconstrained two-way fixed-effects models. Across the six models, the estimated effect of political incivility is nontrivial: A two standard deviation increase in incivility drives down political trust by between 5.2 and 6.9 percentage points. Moreover, the four items measuring perceptions of political conflict have no statistically significant effect on political trust

**TABLE 2** Effect of incivility on satisfaction with democracy.

|                          | (1)               | (2)               | (3)               | (4)               | (5)               | (6)               |
|--------------------------|-------------------|-------------------|-------------------|-------------------|-------------------|-------------------|
| Incivility               | -.152**<br>(.017) | -.126**<br>(.026) | -.120**<br>(.027) | -.134**<br>(.032) | -.126**<br>(.042) | -.138**<br>(.040) |
| Incivility <sup>†1</sup> | –                 | –                 | –                 | –                 | .005<br>(.043)    | –.006<br>(.042)   |
| Respondent fixed effects | ✓                 | ✓                 | ✓                 | ✓                 | ✓                 | ✓                 |
| Wave fixed effects       | ✓                 | ✓                 | ✓                 | ✓                 | ✓                 | ✓                 |
| Unit trends              | –                 | –                 | ✓                 | ✓                 | ✓                 | ✓                 |
| Balanced panel           |                   | ✓                 | –                 | ✓                 | –                 | ✓                 |
| Observations             | 13,593            | 5056              | 13,593            | 5056              | 8156              | 4139              |
| Respondents              | 4127              | 959               | 4127              | 959               | 2825              | 934               |

*Note.* Entries are coefficients from ordinary least squares (OLS) regressions testing effects of incivility on satisfaction with democracy with respondent-level clustered standard errors in parentheses.

\* $p < .05$ , \*\* $p < .01$ .

across any of the six models, except for a 2 percentage point effect in one of 24 tests (for results, see page 11 in Section D of the SI). In sum, participants' trust in politicians decreases after they experience increases in political incivility—but not when experiencing changes in issue-related disagreement.

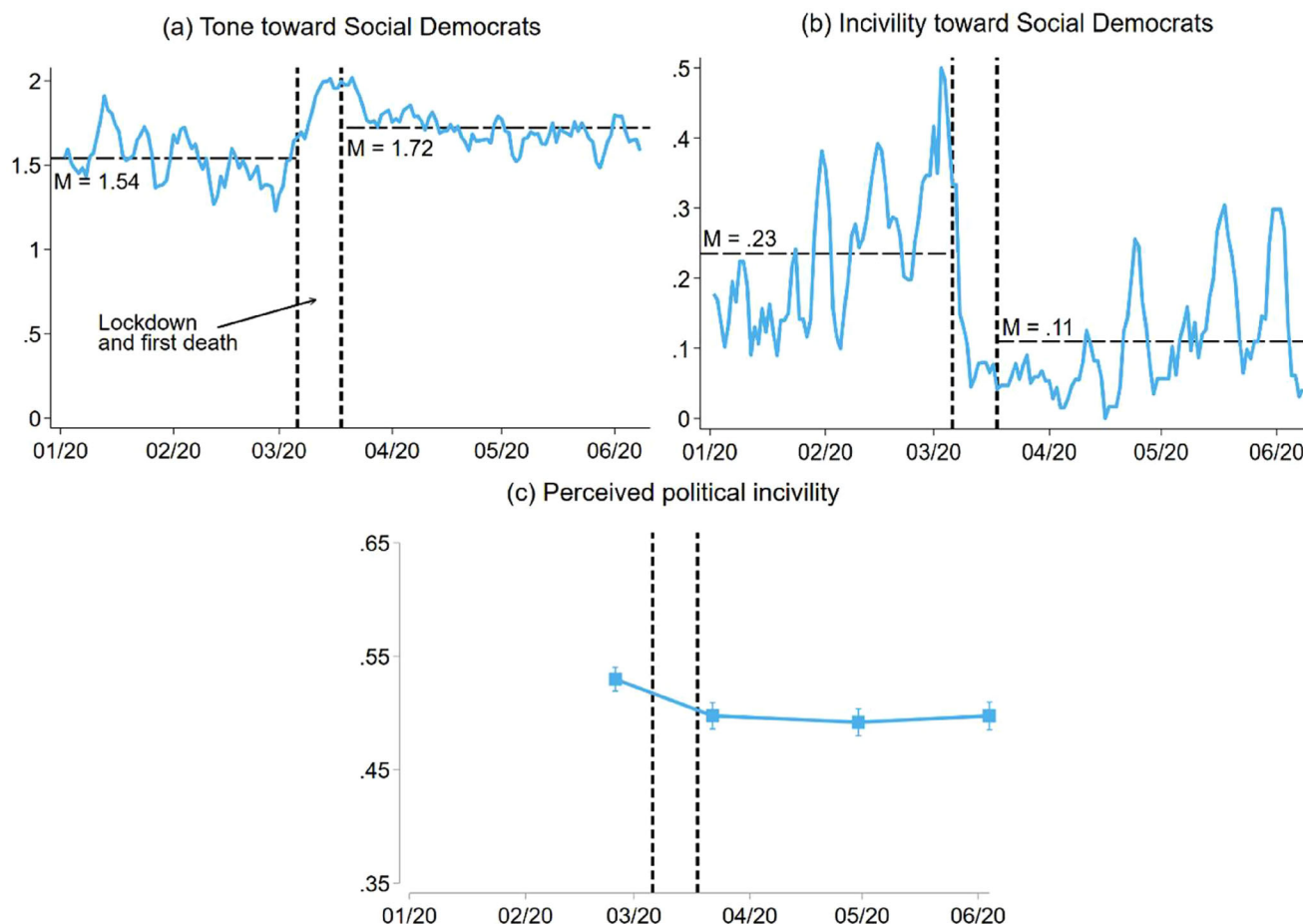
Table 2 reveals an almost identical story regarding the effects on satisfaction with democracy, showing effect sizes between 12 and 15.2 percentage points across model specifications. Again, a two standard deviation increase in political incivility leads to a non-trivial drop in satisfaction with democracy between 4.68 and 5.92 percentage points across the models. Further, in line with the results above, the four items measuring issue-related conflict do not affect satisfaction with democracy across 24 tests (see page 12 in Section D of the SI).

In line with existing work and the theoretical logic outlined above, we find no significant or substantial effects of political incivility on respondents' intentions to vote in the next parliamentary election (<.001 percentage points,  $p = .954$  or higher). The results are reported on page 12 in Section D of the SI. It is possible that these results mask countervailing motivations where some respondents are turned off by uncivil behavior while others are drawn in due to its entertainment value (Brooks & Geer, 2007; Mutz & Reeves, 2005). Our data do not allow us to tease apart these potential mechanisms but only to conclude that the average effect is zero or at least very small. Still, intentions to vote are highly stable in our data and, as such, likely shaped by deeper factors stemming from early socialization rather than elite rhetoric.

While incivility does not seem to have a substantial effect on political engagement in terms of voter participation, our data suggest that it drives down political efficacy, defined as citizens' belief that they can understand and influence political affairs. Further

analyses reveal that a change in political incivility from 0 to 1 decreases political efficacy by between 4.5 and 8.2 percentage points. In two of the six models, the effect on political efficacy is only marginally significant ( $p = .055$  and  $.059$ ). Finally, we find effects of incivility between 6.6 and 13.9 percentage points on a single item from the efficacy index tapping respondents' perceptions of whether politicians "care" about what citizens think. This provides, at least suggestive, evidence for the causal mechanisms proposed above that incivility makes citizens less inclined to believe that politicians care about their welfare and well-being (for operationalization and full results, see pages 13 and 18 in Sections D and F of the SI).

In sum, our findings suggest that incivility—but not issue-related conflict—between politicians drives down citizens' political trust and satisfaction with democracy. Furthermore, incivility does not affect voter participation, but it seems to have adverse effects on citizens' confidence in their own abilities to influence politics and beliefs that politicians and the political system care about their welfare and opinions (as our theory above predicts). Still, these conclusions are tentative. Like the randomized experiment, the generalized difference-in-differences design has limitations and rests on a set of modeling assumptions (for critical reviews, see, e.g., Imai & Kim, 2021). In particular, we estimate the effects of incivility using only respondents' self-reported experiences. Although we validate that these perceptions track real-world changes in political rhetoric (as discussed above), we cannot know for certain whether the reported effects reflect subjects' actual exposure to (un)civil rhetoric or, for example, noise from inattentive subjects. Below, we replicate our findings using a different variant of the difference-in-differences design that exploits a specific event-based politically exogenous shock that led to a sudden drop in incivility between politicians.



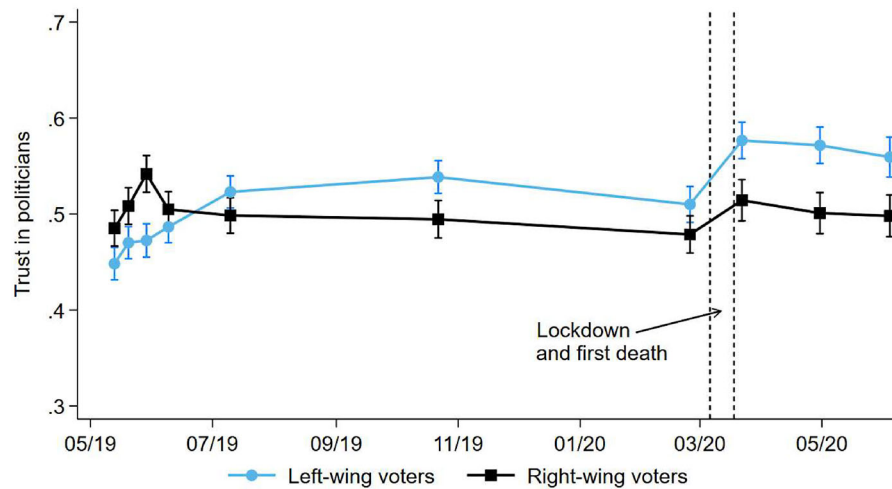
**FIGURE 2** Media tone (panel a) and incivility (panel b) toward Social Democrats and perceptions of political incivility (panel c) before and after the COVID-19 outbreak. *Note:* Average tone (panel a) and proportion of articles with uncivil language (panel b) towards the Social Democrats and respondents' mean perceptions of political incivility (panel c) before and after the COVID-19 outbreak. The y-axis in panel c is restricted to 1.5 standard deviations around the mean to ensure comparability between the visual and actual effect size (Lakens, 2013; Witt, 2019).

## EVIDENCE FROM THE COVID-19 CRISIS

Did the COVID-19 crisis lead to a sudden change in political discourse and perceived political incivility among citizens? Most likely, it did. Panel a of Figure 2 reports the general tone toward the governing party, the Social Democrats, in Danish media based on a content coding of media articles published between January 1 and June 1, 2020 (for details on the coding procedure and intercoder reliability tests, see pages 14–15 in Section E of the SI). The vertical lines indicate the period in which the first death with COVID-19 and the national lockdown occurred (March 6–18, 2020).<sup>7</sup> As displayed, the outbreak of the COVID-19 crisis clearly led to a more positive tone toward the

Social Democrats in Danish media. The average tone was 1.54 on our scale prior to the crisis and rose to an average of 1.72 after the first death and lockdown occurred, amounting to an 11.69% improvement in the average tone ( $p < .01$ ). Panel b shows that the outbreak also resulted in a significant and substantial drop in uncivil language toward the Social Democrats. The average daily proportion of articles mentioning the Social Democrats that contained uncivil remarks toward the Social Democrats dropped from 23% 6 months before the outbreak to 11% after the outbreak ( $p < .01$ ). This resonates with prior research showing that the opposition tends to hold off on attacking the government following the outbreak of a national security crisis (Chowanietz, 2011). To our knowledge, this is the first evidence that the COVID-19 outbreak did, in fact, change the political discourse or rhetoric toward a governing party, which is a key theoretical mechanism in explaining the rally-'round-the-flag effect.

<sup>7</sup> We mark both events in the figures because research suggests that both deaths and lockdowns can contribute to instigating a sense of national security crisis (Schraff, 2021; Vries et al., 2021).



**FIGURE 3** Trust in politicians around COVID-19 outbreak. *Note:* Respondents' mean trust in politicians before and after the COVID-19 outbreak across left- and right-wing voters. The y-axis is restricted to 1.5 standard deviations around the mean.  $N = 12,602$ .

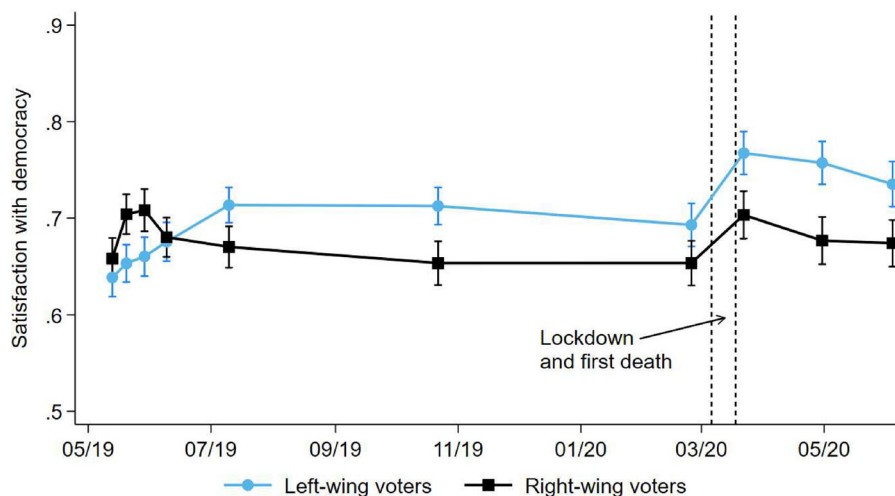
Diving further into this mechanism, panel c of Figure 2 shows that this change in rhetoric was, in fact, noticed among our respondents. Perceptions of political incivility dropped by 3–4 percentage points ( $p < .01$ ) following the crisis outbreak and stayed at this lower level for at least 2.5 months. In contrast, our subjects did not experience systematic changes in perceptions of issue-based conflict between the political parties. If anything, perceptions of conflict on immigration, pensions, and the environment increased. Conflict on the health issue went down by 4.8 percentage points ( $p < .01$ ) in the first wave following the outbreak but moved back to pre-crisis levels in the second and third waves following the crisis. These patterns of perceived conflict mirror behavior in the legislative arena. The volume of bipartisan legislation was the same before and after the outbreak, suggesting that what changed with COVID-19 was less the level of issue-based conflict and more the way politicians engaged with each other rhetorically (for full results, see page 5 in Section B of the SI).

Did changes in trust in politicians and satisfaction with democracy track changes in perceived political incivility following the crisis outbreak? They did. Figure 3 shows that trust in politicians increases for both left- and right-wing party supporters following the COVID-19 crisis. Importantly, this effect persists in the second and third postcrisis waves ( $p$  between .01 and .021), implying that the rally-round-the-flag effect tracks perceptions of incivility, not issue-based political conflict. Figure 4 reveals similar patterns when looking at changes in satisfaction with democracy. Satisfaction with democracy goes up because of the COVID-19 crisis for both left- and right-wing party supporters. Again, this rally effect

remains significant—or in one instance, marginally significant—in the second and third waves following the crisis outbreak ( $p$  between .01 and .056) and thus tracks perceptions of political incivility. Section B of the SI reports additional robustness tests ruling out that the effects emerge, for example, due to systematic panel attrition or increased satisfaction with government policies following the crisis (pages 3–7). These results closely mirror the conclusions from the generalized difference-in-differences models above. Even in the context of very strict policies and a significant economic downturn following a lockdown, trust in politicians and satisfaction with democracy goes up when political incivility drops.

In contrast, vote intentions did not change following the COVID-19 crisis. In fact, intentions to vote at the next parliamentary election were so stable before and during the crisis outbreak that there is not enough within-individual variation to conduct a formal test of the relationship. While vote intentions did not change, political efficacy increased among both left-wing supporters (between 5.6 and 6.3 percentage points,  $p < .01$ ) and right-wing supporters (between 3.5 and 4.2 percentage points,  $p < .01$ ) following the crisis outbreak. Moreover, perceptions of whether politicians care about citizens' welfare and well-being increased among both left-wing (between 8.6 and 9 percentage points) and right-wing supporters (between 4.8 and 5.6 percentage points), providing further suggestive evidence for the theoretical mechanism proposed above (for results, see pages 18–19 in Section F of the SI). Overall, these results are remarkably consistent with the findings from the generalized difference-in-differences models and paint a clear picture of the consequences of political incivility.





**FIGURE 4** Satisfaction with democracy around COVID-19 outbreak. *Note:* Respondents' mean satisfaction with democracy before and after the COVID-19 outbreak across left- and right-wing voters. The y-axis is restricted to 1.5 standard deviations around the mean.  $N = 12,455$ .

Even so, it is possible that these effects reflect how citizens responded to other aspects of the crisis outbreak than the change in incivility. After all, a national security crisis initiates multiple political processes and is essentially a compound treatment. To gain causal traction and test the proposed theoretical mechanism at work, we move to the difference-in-differences logic and test if the rally effects are larger among left-wing (i.e., government) compared to right-wing (i.e., opposition) party supporters.

Again, the parallel trends assumption is key. If we inspect the point estimates from the three surveys immediately prior to the COVID-19 crisis in Figures 3 and 4, left- and right-wing party supporters exhibit similar pre-trends in political trust and satisfaction with democracy. From these point estimates, it is also clear that the left-wing party supporters exhibit higher absolute levels in both trust in politicians and satisfaction with democracy. Different absolute levels can be problematic unless there is a logical explanation for these differences that occurs before and is independent of the event or treatment of interest (Angrist & Pischke, 2008). This explanation becomes apparent when looking at the point estimates from the first five surveys in the figures: Before the 2019 national election in June, political trust and satisfaction with democracy were highest among the right-wing party supporters whose parties were in power; however, after the left-wing government was elected, this difference flipped, leading to higher trust and satisfaction among left-wing party supporters. In short, the figures demonstrate the well-established winner-loser effect (Anderson et al., 2005) and that the different absolute levels between left-wing and right-wing party supporters are a function of the election result 9 months prior to the onset of the crisis.

Are the increases in political trust and satisfaction with democracy following the COVID-19 crisis larger among left-wing (government) compared to right-wing (opposition) party supporters? Figures 3 and 4 graphically illustrate that the increase in both instances is steeper for left-wing supporters and that the difference remains for at least 2.5 months. Table 3 reports the formal tests with difference-in-differences estimates. Model 1 reports that the differences in political trust between pre- and postcrisis waves are between 4.6 and 6.3 percentage points for left-wing party supporters ( $p < .01$ ). The interaction terms show how much these differences are diminished when turning to right-wing party supporters (i.e., difference-in-differences estimates). The interaction term coefficients are between 2.6 and 3.6 percentage points and imply that the rally effect is at least cut in half when moving from left-wing to right-wing party supporters ( $p < .05$ ). Model 2 tells a very similar story for satisfaction with democracy with between 3 and 4.7 percentage points larger effects among left-wing supporters ( $p < .05$ ). Section B in the SI reports robustness tests that further underline that the effects emerge due to differences in party identification rather than other demographic or political characteristics (pages 8–10). The same pattern emerges when analyzing political efficacy as the dependent variable (see page 18 in Section F of the SI).

Finally, we analyze how incivility between politicians affects self-reported intentions to comply with COVID-19 restrictions. Public compliance with these guidelines was vital for containing the virus and keeping deaths to a minimum, and, as such, we analyze downstream consequences of political incivility of societal importance at the time. We cannot make use of the COVID-19 outbreak as an event-based

**TABLE 3** Changes in trust in politicians (Model 1) and satisfaction with democracy (Model 2) over the COVID-19 outbreak across government and opposition supporters.

|                                          | Trust in politicians<br>(1) | Satisfaction with democracy<br>(2) |
|------------------------------------------|-----------------------------|------------------------------------|
| Pre-COVID-19 wave                        | –                           | –                                  |
|                                          | –                           | –                                  |
| First post-wave                          | .063**<br>(.007)            | .077**<br>(.010)                   |
| Second post-wave                         | .061**<br>(.007)            | .068**<br>(.010)                   |
| Third post-wave                          | .046**<br>(.007)            | .047**<br>(.010)                   |
| Left-wing supporters                     | –                           | –                                  |
|                                          | –                           | –                                  |
| First post-wave × Right-wing supporters  | –.032**<br>(.010)           | –.030*<br>(.014)                   |
| Second post-wave × Right-wing supporters | –.036**<br>(.010)           | –.047**<br>(.014)                  |
| Third post-wave × Right-wing supporters  | –.026*<br>(.010)            | –.032*<br>(.014)                   |
| Constant                                 | .501**<br>(.003)            | .678**<br>(.004)                   |
| Participant FE                           | ✓                           | ✓                                  |
| Observations                             | 12,602                      | 12,455                             |
| Participants                             | 4161                        | 4108                               |

*Note:* Entries are coefficients from ordinary least squares (OLS) regressions testing effects of incivility on trust in politicians and satisfaction with democracy with respondent-level clustered standard errors in parentheses. For the variable distinguishing between survey waves, the pre-COVID-19 survey wave is the reference category. For the variable distinguishing left- and right-wing supporters, left-wing supporters is the reference category. All survey waves displayed in Figures 3 and 4 are contained in the models but not reported in the table for simplicity.

\* $p < .05$ , \*\* $p < .01$ .

shock and apply a specific difference-in-differences design since it would not be meaningful (or practically possible) to ask questions about compliance with COVID-19 restrictions prior to the outbreak. Instead, we return to the generalized difference-in-differences design. Since we only observe compliance intentions in the two final waves, we have fewer observations compared to the models above, and we cannot investigate the parallel trends assumption. The results should be interpreted with these reservations in mind.

Table 4 reports results from a two-way fixed-effects model with the compliance index as the dependent variable. The table reveals a negative 12.6 percentage point effect of political incivility on compliance intentions. This effect is statistically significant ( $p = .037$ ) but moves above the .05 threshold when leaving out certain combinations of the control variables. Hence, the effect is less robust compared to the results presented above. With that said, the results suggest that incivility does, in fact, have negative downstream consequences for compliance with public policy. A two standard deviation increase in political inci-

**TABLE 4** Effect of incivility on intentions to comply with COVID-19 policies.

|                          |                  |
|--------------------------|------------------|
| Incivility               | –.126*<br>(.061) |
| Respondent fixed effects | ✓                |
| Wave fixed effects       | ✓                |
| Observations             | 1492             |
| Respondents              | 746              |

*Note:* Entries are coefficients from ordinary least squares (OLS) regressions testing the effect of incivility on compliance with COVID-19 policies with respondent-level clustered standard errors in parentheses. The model controls for political interest, political ideology, perceptions of the economy, the government's handling of health care, immigration, pensions, the environment, and the economy, and perceived conflict on health care, immigration, pensions, and the environment.

\* $p < .05$ , \*\* $p < .01$ .

vility amounts to a 4.92 percentage point drop in compliance intentions. Such differences can be critical in a public health crisis in which relatively few non-complying individuals can cause exponential infection rates and deaths.

## DISCUSSION

Incivility between politicians carries important downstream effects on citizens' political and systemic attitudes. Incivility drives down what Norris (2017) labels specific support for the political system (here, trust in incumbent politicians), depresses more general or diffuse support for the system's regime (here, satisfaction with democracy), and endangers its capacity for problem solving (here, voluntary policy compliance; see also Easton, 1957). Against this background, we conclude that recent surges in political incivility are indeed legitimate grounds for concern.

Even so, our findings also hint to positive conclusions about the current state of politics and democracy in three ways. First, we consistently find that citizens' intentions to vote in national elections do not respond to actual or perceived changes in political incivility. This may imply either that political incivility activates countervailing mechanisms (see, e.g., Sydnor, 2019) or that democratic participation is a product of norm-based socialization that runs deeper than elite rhetoric. This finding must be interpreted with the reservation that we only study intended participation in elections and no other types of participation such as everyday attention to politics and inclinations to engage in political discussion.

Second, it is noteworthy that substantial issue-related conflict between politicians does not depress political trust, satisfaction with democracy, vote intentions, or policy compliance. Representative democracy requires, almost by definition, some amount of competition and conflict between elites (Dahl, 1971), and it is encouraging that there is no apparent trade-off between elite competition and citizens' support for the political system. Brooks and Geer (2007) and Skytte (2021) come to similar conclusions based on survey experimental evidence.

Third, our findings from the COVID-19 crisis suggest that a drop in political incivility at the outset of security crises is a valuable resource that sets off rally-'round-the-flag effects and, in turn, improves compliance with crisis policies among citizens. It may be of critical importance for political elites to make use of this opportunity and maintain low levels of incivility for as long as possible to ensure proper crisis management and containment before incivility levels return to normal and crisis fatigue sets in (see Jørgensen et al., 2022).

Aside from their substantive implications, we also believe that our findings—in conjunction with the existing literature—carry methodological lessons about the potentials and pitfalls of different research designs in the study of public opinion. Survey experiments in and outside of the incivility literature have been criticized for overestimating treatment effects by

using unrealistic and extreme stimuli and invariably assigning them to all participants regardless of participants' likelihood of receiving the stimuli in the real world. Although this is likely true in some instances, our design studying citizens in their real-life information environment underscores that many citizens do, in fact, notice real-world political developments such as a change in elite rhetoric, and that such developments are sufficient to yield effects on, for example, political trust that are of similar size—or even larger—than those reported in many experimental studies (cf. Van't Riet & Van Stekelenburg, 2022). Accordingly, the main drawback of survey experiments may not be that they overestimate effect sizes but rather that they underestimate or fail to detect effects and outcomes of substantial importance: As survey experiments almost exclusively gauge effects of one-shot treatments, they tend to display short-lived effects and fail to detect effects on systemic attitudes such as satisfaction with democracy or basic willingness to comply with the law.

We are also well aware that our panel data are not without limitations. The generalized difference-in-differences model is subject to critical debate (e.g., Imai & Kim, 2021) and, invariably, offers less certainty regarding internal validity compared to the randomized experiment. That said, it lends credence to this approach that its results consistently replicate with our specific or event-based difference-in-differences approach. Moreover, it increases our confidence in the conclusions that at least some previous survey experimental studies also report effects of incivility on political trust and, on average, find no effects on political participation (Van't Riet & Van Stekelenburg, 2022). In contrast, we need additional replication studies that analyze effects on satisfaction with democracy and intentions to comply—or better yet behavioral compliance—with public policy. Finally, it is worth investigating whether there are more extreme consequences of political incivility such as hate, threats, or violence directed at (out-party) politicians.

In closing, future work on political incivility should devote more attention to context. On the one hand, we expect that negative reactions to incivility are natural and, to a certain extent, universal, meaning that the results from the Danish case likely travel to other countries. On the other hand, it is very likely that political incivility's prevalence, visibility, and, in turn, effects on citizens vary by institutions and political culture. A recent meta-analysis suggests that incivility has larger effects in Europe compared to the United States (Van't Riet & Van Stekelenburg, 2022). While interesting and plausible, this possible variation raises several questions. For example, does affective polarization dampen or intensify the effects of political incivility? Do personalized political systems and election campaigns make political incivility more prevalent or

visible to citizens? How universal or culturally dependent are norms about civility? We hope that our theory of downstream consequences, research designs, and cross-nationally validated scale of political incivility will help push forward a systematic, comparative research agenda addressing these issues.

## ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

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## SUPPORTING INFORMATION

Additional supporting information can be found online in the Supporting Information section at the end of this article.

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